

INDIA'S LAST WINDOW FOR COMPUTATIONAL LEADERSHIP

Delay Now Means Permanent Dependence

India missed the first wave of the AI revolution. Not because we lacked talent, intelligence, or ambition, but because we chose hesitation over execution. While others moved with speed and clarity, we buried decisions under committees, policy drafts, and bureaucratic caution. The result is now obvious. The United States, China, and a small group of nations control the computational frontier. They build the models, own the infrastructure, and set the rules. We consume. We follow.

We cannot afford to repeat this failure.

Artificial intelligence and advanced computation are not just technologies. They are power. They determine economic competitiveness, military capability, industrial strength, and national sovereignty. Nations that control compute, chips, data, and foundational models will shape global standards and strategic outcomes. Nations that do not will live inside systems designed by others. Dependence in technology quickly becomes dependence in defense, economy, and policy. Once entrenched, it is nearly impossible to reverse.

Our failure was structural. Authority was fragmented across ministries with no clear ownership. Talent was scattered across institutions that competed instead of coordinated. Funding was timid, short-term, and hostile to risk. Universities produced brilliant graduates but offered no path to real-world impact. Research remained isolated from industry. Startups struggled for compute, capital, and customers. We celebrated brain drain as success and called remittances a strategy. We rewarded procedure over outcomes and conformity over courage. While the world built, we debated.

Others did not wait. China integrated universities, industry, and the state into a single computational machine. The United States funded risk, moved fast, and deployed at scale. Even smaller nations built focused centers of excellence and aggressively attracted global talent. They understood a simple truth we avoided: AI is not an academic exercise. It is national infrastructure.

If we continue on our current path, permanent dependence is inevitable. Our economy will license foreign models and export intellectual value. High-impact innovation will happen elsewhere. Our defense systems will rely on technology we do not fully control or trust. Our sovereignty will erode as others define standards we must accept. This is not a distant threat. It is already unfolding.

This is our last window to act.

The response must be ruthless, focused, and executable.

First, commit. Computational leadership must be declared a national priority with clear authority, binding timelines, and real accountability. Fragmented ownership must end. Speed must take precedence over institutional comfort.

Second, invest. At a scale that reflects strategic seriousness. Compute infrastructure, chips, data centers, and long-horizon research funding are non-negotiable. Ten-year commitments, not annual uncertainty. Failure must be tolerated. Chronic underfunding guarantees irrelevance.

Third, build. National-scale AI compute clusters, secure research clouds, and domestic hardware capability. Institutions that execute, not merely publish. Procurement and regulation rebuilt for speed rather than paralysis.

Fourth, invite. Global researchers, engineers, and founders must see India as a place where work matters and impact is real. Frictionless visas, competitive compensation, and research autonomy are essential. At the same time, we must stop bleeding domestic talent by aligning education with real systems, deployment, and national missions.

Finally, deploy. Across governance, healthcare, defense, infrastructure, and industry. Not pilots. Real systems. Deployment creates data. Data creates learning. Learning creates leadership. If we do not deploy our own systems, we will import dependence by default.

We must abandon endless consultation, fragmented authority, cosmetic innovation, fear-driven regulation, and the illusion that time is on our side. It is not. Every delay compounds disadvantage.

This is not about pride. It is about survival. The age of intelligence rewards speed, scale, and control. There is no safe middle path. India either acts now or accepts permanent follower status.

Tomorrow is bright, if and only if we have the courage and commitment to switch on the light today.

To end, we leave you with a line from a very popular video game that captures the urgency of this moment:

“Arise now, ye Tarnished. Ye dead, who yet live.”

— *Elden Ring*

Glory to the Motherland. Glory to her People. Glory to her Future.

Jai Hind.

Aditya Mishra

Laith Shaikh

Meet Jain

Soham Sahay